

Kitchen Singers Become Surprise Social Media Stars

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Lots of people try hard to become famous online. A group of singers near Philadelphia, Pennsylvania, found fame without even trying.

The group is called the Tonics. It is an **a cappella** group, which means the members sing without any instruments. Most of the 18 members are dads and grandfathers. They range in age from their 30s to their 70s, and they practice in each other's homes, often gathered around a kitchen island.

Last year, the Tonics had about 500 followers on Instagram. Then, in December, they posted a video of a **rehearsal** of the 1970s song "Drift Away." The video quickly got 300,000 views. Other videos got thousands and then tens of thousands of views. One got more than 4 million.

"We were shocked, and we're like, 'How did this happen?'" said Youngmoo Kim, 53, the group's music director.

Part of the answer was Emilie Hagen, an online **influencer** who began sharing the group with her more than 130,000 followers. "They felt **authentic** and **wholesome**," Hagen told NPR. "They didn't feel like they were on the internet to get famous."

The group started in 1990 with friends from high school and college. Members include teachers, a **pediatrician** and people who work in business. Some say singing together helps them keep a hobby they loved in college and make good friends.

Today, the Tonics have close to 100,000 Instagram followers. That is far more than some famous college **a cappella** groups. Strangers sometimes recognize them, and the group plans to release four new songs on Spotify later this year.

"We don't take ourselves seriously," Kim said. His advice is simple: just be yourself.

Word Treasure

a cappella -- A cappella means singing with voices only, without any musical instruments.

rehearsal -- A rehearsal is a practice session to get ready for a performance.

influencer -- An influencer is a person with many online followers who can get people interested in things.

authentic -- Authentic means real and true to who you are, not fake.

wholesome -- Wholesome means good, kind and suitable for everyone.

pediatrician -- A pediatrician is a doctor who takes care of children.

Background you need

A cappella singing uses only human voices, with singers covering the melody, harmonies and even rhythm sounds themselves.

Many high schools and colleges have a cappella groups, but most people stop singing in them after they graduate.

On social media, a video can suddenly reach huge numbers of people when viewers and popular accounts share it with their followers.

A music director leads a group's rehearsals, picks songs and helps the singers blend their voices.

Break it down

LEAD: A singing group near Philadelphia found online fame without trying

KEY EVENT: A December rehearsal video of "Drift Away" quickly got 300,000 views

+ - WHO: The Tonics, 18 mostly dads and grandfathers, led by music director Youngmoo Kim

+ - WHERE: Rehearsals in members' homes, often around a kitchen island

EVIDENCE: Growth from about 500 followers to close to 100,000; one video passed 4 million views

WHY IT WORKED: Influencer Emilie Hagen says they felt authentic and wholesome

WHAT'S NEXT: Four new songs on Spotify later this year

Why it matters

The Tonics show that people can find an audience online by sharing what they love and being themselves, and that hobbies and friendships can last a lifetime.

Test what you remember

1. What does it mean that the Tonics are an a cappella group?
 - (A) They sing without any instruments
 - (B) They only sing in Italian
 - (C) They only play drums
 - (D) They perform only at night
2. About how many Instagram followers did the Tonics have last year before their video spread?
 - (A) About 18
 - (B) About 4 million
 - (C) About 100,000
 - (D) About 500
3. Which song was in the December video that quickly got 300,000 views?
 - (A) "Drift Away"
 - (B) "Uncertain, TX"
 - (C) "Here"
 - (D) "Lost in Translation"
4. Who helped share the Tonics with her more than 130,000 followers?
 - (A) A college professor
 - (B) Emilie Hagen
 - (C) A famous pop star
 - (D) Youngmoo Kim
5. When did the group start?
 - (A) In 2026
 - (B) In the 1970s
 - (C) Last December
 - (D) In 1990
6. What does the group plan to do later this year?
 - (A) Release four new songs on Spotify
 - (B) Stop posting videos
 - (C) Move to New York
 - (D) Go on a world tour

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: D 3: A 4: B 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Influencer Emilie Hagen: She says the Tonics felt authentic and wholesome and were not on the internet just to get famous.
2. Music director Youngmoo Kim: He says the group does not take itself seriously and that the lesson is to just be yourself.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):